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UCE ENGLISH 2026
MARKING GUIDE

UGANDA NATIONAL EXAMINATIONS BOARD

Uganda Certificate of Education

112/1 ENGLISH LANGUAGE, Paper 1, Oct./Nov. 2026 (2 hours)

QUESTIONS AND RESPONSES

INSTRUCTIONS TO CANDIDATES

This examination paper consists of two sections: A and B. It has four items.

Section A is compulsory.

Respond to one item from Section B.

Respond to three items in all.

Responses to all items must be written in the spaces provided.

Any additional item(s) responded to will not be scored.

SECTION A

QUESTION 1 (Item 1)

You live in a community where most people are not aware of the dangers of prolonged sitting and how to reduce them. Your school has organised a community outreach programme that includes sensitisation. As the prefect in charge of health in your school, you have been selected as one of the presenters.

Task:

In a paragraph of about 120 words, write down what you will present to the community gathering, based on the extract below.

In the modern world, sitting has become an ever-present part ofour daily lives. From working at a desk to lounging on the couch, many of us spend a significant portion of our day sitting down. While it may seem like a harmless activity, research has shown that prolonged sitting can have serious health consequences.

With the advent of technology, more jobs require us to sit in front of a computer for hours. Additionally, our leisure activities often involve sitting, whether we are watching TV, playing video games, or browsing social media. This shift towards a more sedentary lifestyle has contributed to a range of health problems that affect people of all ages, a reason as to why everyone must rethink how long they sit daily. When we sit for long periods, our blood flow slows down, allowing fatty acids to build up in the blood vessels. This can lead to the formation of plaques, increasing the risk of heart attacks and cutting our lives short.

Sitting for extended periods can lead to weight gain and obesity. When we sit, we burn fewer calories compared to when we stand or move around. This can result in an imbalance between the calories we consume and those we expend, leading to weight gain. Obesity, in turn, is a significant risk factor for other illnesses which include conditions like high blood pressure, high blood sugar and abnormal cholesterol levels. Sitting for long periods can negatively affect our body's ability to regulate blood sugar levels. Studies have shown that prolonged sitting can lead to insulin resistance, a condition where the body's cells do not respond effectively to insulin.

Sitting for long periods can strain our muscles and joints. Poor posture, often associated with prolonged sitting, can lead to back and neck pain as well as problems with the shoulders and hips. Over time, these issues can become chronic and significantly impact our quality of life.

A sedentary lifestyle can affect our mental health. Research suggests that prolonged sitting can increase the risk of depression and anxiety. Physical activity, on the other hand, has been shown to boost our mood levels.

The good news is that there are several simple strategies we can adopt to reduce the amount of time we spend sitting and improve our overall health. One of the easiest ways to reduce sitting time is to take frequent breaks, standing up, stretching and moving around for a few minutes every hour. Setting a timer on one's phone, watch or computer can serve as a helpful reminder to take these breaks. Look for opportunities to stand rather than sit. For example, consider using a standing desk

at work or a high table for activities like reading or writing. One can also stand while talking on the phone or watching television.

Walking is a great way to break up long periods of sitting. Try to incorporate more walking into your daily routine. This could be as simple as taking a short walk during your lunch break, parking your car further away from your destination, or taking the stairs instead of the elevator.

Regular exercise is crucial for counteracting the negative effects ofprolonged sitting. Aim for 150 minutes of moderate intensity aerobic activity, such as brisk walking each week. Additionally, include muscle strengthening activities like weightlifting at least twice a week.

Whenever possible, opt for active modes of transportation, such as walking or cycling instead of driving or using a motorcycle. This not only helps reduce sitting time, but also provides a great opportunity to get some exercise. Park as far off as possible to create opportunity to walk. Make sure you wear comfortable shoes for walking.

It is also important to choose hobbies that involve physical activity rather than those that require sitting. Farming activities, dancing and sports are all excellent options that can help one stay active. When one needs to sit and use a computer, they must be mindful of their posture. Sit up straight with your back supported and your feet flat on the floor. Adjust your chair and desk to ensure that the computer screen is at eye level and your arms are at a comfortable angle.

Find creative ways to incorporate movement into your daily routine. For example, do some light exercises or stretches while watching television, or walk around the house during commercial breaks. Even small busts of activity can add up and help reduce the negative effects of prolonged sitting. Pick things instead of sending people to bring them to you.

(Adapted from: *The New Vision*, Monday November 25, 2024.)

RESPONSE

Good afternoon, dear community members. I am the prefect in charge of health at our school, and I have come to talk about the danger of sitting for too long. Sitting for hours slows the

blood, adds weight, raises blood sugar, strains the back and joints, and even brings sadness and worry. These problems affect everyone, young and old. Fortunately, we can fight them. Stand and stretch every hour, walk or cycle instead of riding, and choose farming, dancing and sports for leisure. Aim for about 150 minutes of brisk activity every week, and sit upright when using a computer. Small habits, such as taking the stairs, add up. Let us move more and live longer. Thank you.

QUESTION 2 (Item 2)

Read the text below and respond to the tasks.

At school, I was affected by that continued laziness that is often among young students who think they are especially clever and can pass any examination through sheer genius. After passing my Ordinary Level with nine aggregates and no sweat at all, I went to Tendo College for Advanced Level. I remember my goal then — to be a nuclear physicist. And if that was too advanced for the Third World, then I would gracefully step down and just be a research scientist.

My Advanced Level was a disaster. What could I blame it on? Play, alcohol or drugs? I blame it on all, plus the sort of risky confidence that comes after you have been top of the class too many times. Of my days at Tendo College, I remember the movies and parties rather than what happened in the laboratories. When the final results came out, I realised I was on a bad trip that just would not end up in the university. It was bad and shocking!

Students I was better than got called up to the university. As for me, I was bad news in the academic circles. Trying to save face, I applied feverishly to foreign universities. My father could afford to send me to one. But no foreign university seemed interested. I kept trying until my father told me that if I was intending to go abroad, I would have to do it myself.

My father, his friends and enemies call him GM, was no kid-spoiler. Although he could afford to send me round the world seven times, he was not going to help because I had proved to be a failure. If I had failed at home, I would not succeed abroad. I realised from his bitter comments that he knew about the kind of life I had led at Tendo College. Could he then seriously think of sending me to America?

"Go on your own," said my father. He had turned a blind eye to my mischief until I let him down and failed to make it to the university. And my father is not the kind of man you let down and get away with it. He himself had never failed. Where he could not work his way out smoothly, he bulldozed. If the front door was closed, he tried the back door. That was the way he made his millions in the construction business.

Sons of poor men were going to universities, so why not GM's firstborn? He felt betrayed. What was it that he had not done for me? My pocket money had been a huge sum. He bought me all books that I wanted. So, why had I not gone to the university?

I agree that GM had spoilt me. But all the money and stuff he gave me was on the understanding that I would live up to his expectations, which I did until 'A' level. In fact, I did more.

At seventeen, I was the maintenance man at home, one who knew what was wrong with the TV, fridge or even his car. Father could not even

change his own car plugs. He trusted me to service his car and considered me the last word in wiring, Now you understand the huge sum of pocket money. I spent most of it on drugs!

After I had failed, my father did not want to see me around. He does not easily reconsider his decisions. He had dug up my Tendo College background and it had shocked him so much that he did not want me to even touch his car.

What finally broke our relationship was when the disciplinarian father in him came to the surface and he thought he could teach me a physical lesson just because my room smelt of something strange. He had sniffed and realised it was drugs.

The rest is embarrassing. There was yet another side of me that he had not known. I had a panther's reflexes that had come from my secret judo and karate classes. I did not hurt him at all but he stared at me from the floor with great surprise. Through his open mouth, I saw a little film of blood on his small white teeth — nothing serious.

After that, there was nothing else to do except to pack. The mansion at Bulamagi was a bit too small for both of us. I still regret everything to this day!

(Adapted from: *A High Voltage Affair off Flight to Juba* by Sam Kahinga, Longman 1979)

Respond appropriately to each of the following tasks according to the text above:

(a)

'The mansion at Bulamagi was a bit too small for both of us.' What does the writer mean, and why?

RESPONSE

The writer means that after the fight he and his father could no longer live together in the same house. Although the mansion was large, the anger, shame and distrust between them filled it. The father felt betrayed by his son's failure and drug use, and the son had humiliated him physically, so one of them had to leave and the narrator packed.

(b)

"Go on your own," said my father. (Report the words of the father to his son.)

RESPONSE

My father told me to go on my own.

(Other acceptable: My father ordered me to go on my own.)

(c)

'Where he could not work his way out smoothly, he bulldozed. If the front door was closed, he tried the back door. That was the way he made his millions in the construction business.' Explain the personality of GM as presented in these sentences.

RESPONSE

GM is determined, forceful and resourceful. The verb "bulldozed" shows that he pushed aside obstacles with great force when gentle methods failed. Trying the back door when the front door was closed shows that he never accepted defeat and always found another way, even if the method was not entirely straightforward. These qualities made him a millionaire.

(d)

Stories are experiences that are meant to shape the way we live and interact with others. Show how the experiences in this text influence your outlook to life.

RESPONSE

The narrator's failure has taught me that talent without effort leads nowhere, so I will not depend on being clever. His drug use has shown me how quickly bad habits can ruin a bright future, and I will avoid bad company and drugs. I have also learned that the trust and gifts of parents come with expectations, and that respectful conversation, not violence, must settle disagreements at home. I will therefore work hard, appreciate my parents and solve conflicts calmly.

(e)

Authors write different texts for a variety of reasons, that is to say they always have a message to pass on or convey through their pieces of writing. Comment on the intention of the writer above.

RESPONSE

The writer intends to warn young people that cleverness, wealth and comfort do not guarantee success, and that laziness, drugs and indiscipline destroy opportunities. He also cautions parents that spoiling a child with money, or reacting with sudden violent discipline, can break a family. By letting the narrator speak with regret in the first person, he makes the lesson sincere and invites readers to reflect on their own conduct.

(f)

The way we handle a sensitive issue determines the outcome. If you had been the son to GM, how would you have behaved when faced with this challenge that finally breaks up their relationship? Justify your choice.

RESPONSE

I would have stayed calm, accepted my fault and apologised instead of fighting back. I would have admitted that I used drugs and asked my father for a chance to seek help from a counsellor or a respected relative. This choice is wise because violence only worsens anger, while honesty and humility can rebuild trust. It would also have kept the family together and given me a chance to repeat my Advanced Level.

SECTION B

QUESTION 3 (Item 3)

There is a growing rate of environmental degradation. Forests are being cut down, swamps and wetlands are being drained, and toxic fumes are being released by industries. The leaders and government agencies responsible to condemn these acts seem thin on the ground and, therefore, overwhelmed. This has created numerous problems and raises serious concerns for the near future. A local newspaper has organised a writing competition to help in mass sensitisation. You are a young writer that is deeply concerned by the occurrences.

Task:

In about 250 – 300 words, write to the Editor of the Real Time Newspaper.

RESPONSE

P.O. Box 214,
Mbale.
20th October 2026

The Editor,
Real Time Newspaper,
P.O. Box 1050,
Kampala.

Dear Sir or Madam,

THE CRY OF OUR FORESTS, WETLANDS AND SKIES

I am a young writer, and I am responding to your newspaper's competition with an appeal to the public and to our leaders about the growing destruction of our environment.

Everywhere I look, I see damage. Forests that once sheltered birds and fed our rivers are being cut down for charcoal and timber. Swamps and wetlands, which act as nature's sponges, are being drained for farms and buildings. Meanwhile, some factories release toxic fumes and waste into the air and water without shame.

The consequences are already here. Floods sweep away homes and gardens, droughts dry up wells, and families breathe polluted air that causes coughs and other illnesses. If this continues, our children will inherit a barren land.

What worries me most is that those entrusted with protecting the environment seem too few and too weak. Offices lack vehicles and funds, offenders pay small fines or go free, and laws exist mainly on paper. The responsible agencies must therefore be given resources to act, and they must be held accountable when they fail.

Some people say that these matters belong to the government alone. I disagree. Every tree we cut and every stream we pollute leaves a mark, so every citizen must play a part.

I propose three steps. Government agencies should enforce environmental laws strictly and punish offenders. Industries should install filters and treat their waste. Citizens, especially the youth, should plant trees, protect wetlands and report illegal activities.

Let us act now, because the land we destroy today is the home we shall need tomorrow.

Yours faithfully,
Namugga Sarah

QUESTION 4 (Item 4)

Your school, Alexa Academy, has a number of clubs, and each student is required to belong to one of them. Your club held a meeting at the beginning of the week and discussed a number of issues, including starting a club project within the school and coming up with club identification symbols, among other matters. You are the club secretary.

Task:

In about 250 – 300 words, write the proceedings of the meeting.

RESPONSE

MINUTES OF THE ALEXA ACADEMY GREEN CLUB MEETING HELD ON MONDAY, 12TH OCTOBER 2026, AT 4:00 P.M. IN THE SCIENCE LABORATORY

Present: Nakato Rose (Chairperson), Mugabe Allan (Vice Chairperson), Okello Brian (Treasurer), Atuhaire Joan (Secretary), Mr Ssemakula (Patron) and twenty other members.

Absent with apology: Namuli Esther.

Minute 1: Call to order and opening prayer. The Chairperson called the meeting to order at 4:05 p.m. Atuhaire Joan led the opening prayer.

Minute 2: Minutes of the previous meeting. The Secretary read the minutes of the last meeting. After the date had been corrected, they were adopted, proposed by Okello Brian and seconded by Mugabe Allan.

Minute 3: Club project. The Chairperson reported that the administration had approved a club project within the school. Members proposed a tree nursery, a vegetable garden and a waste-recycling corner. After debate, it was resolved that the club would establish a tree nursery near the school gate, because it was affordable and would protect the environment. A committee of five, led by Mugabe Allan, was formed to plan the project. The Treasurer reported that the club had UGX 85,000 and that each member would contribute UGX 2,000 for seeds and tools.

Minute 4: Club identification symbols. Members suggested a motto, a badge and a uniform. It was agreed that the motto would be “Plant Today, Breathe Tomorrow”, that the badge would show a green tree inside a circle, and that members would wear green T-shirts. Nakato Rose and Atuhaire Joan were asked to bring sketches of the badge to the next meeting.

Minute 5: Any other business. The Patron, Mr Ssemakula, advised members to keep records of the seedlings planted. He promised to ask the Agriculture Department for free seeds.

Minute 6: Closing. The Chairperson thanked members for attending. The meeting ended at 5:10 p.m. The next meeting will be held on Monday, 26th October 2026.

Signed: ..... Secretary Signed: ..... Chairperson
Date: .....